

DO YOU REALLY WANT TO LIVE FOREVER?

If it feels like life is too short, you might contemplate the dream of immortality. Without disease or aging, the only threats to people would be accidents, suicides, or murders. The longer you live, the greater the risk of accidental death. Average life expectancy would be about 1,200 years and the maximum 25,000 years. So, what is the enduring appeal of eternal life?

EGYPTIAN EFFORTS

Part of the reason why people long for immortality is the inherent fear of death. It is inevitable that we will die, though none of us is aware of how or when that will be. The ancient Egyptians were obsessed with having eternal life. The pharaohs (Egyptian kings and queens) built tombs to house their bodies and belongings for the journey to the afterlife. According to their religion, everyone was born with a ka (life force) and a ba (personality) that survived death. The body was mummified (preserved) over 70 days so that the ka had something to live in for the next life. In the underworld, the ba had to pass a test from Thoth, the god of wisdom, to gain entry to the kingdom of Osiris, where everlasting life was the reward.

LIFE'S LIMITS

Biologically, death occurs when the body stops working, usually because it is exhausted by age or ravaged by disease. Evolution suggests that the purpose of life is to reproduce, so once people have had children, their work is done and there's no reason to remain on Earth. Some people believe that reproduction is a form of immortality as genes are passed on through the generations. Today, even the healthiest person would struggle to live beyond 120 years because the body's natural repair systems stop working then. It's not all bad news, though. Most people can now expect to live longer, and those in developed countries can expect to live

at least 80 years. However, if you were born in a wealthy country in the early 1900s, your life expectancy would have been only about 50 years. This increase is mostly due to advances in modern medicine, improvements to health services, and recognition of the importance of a good diet and exercise over the past 100 years. But not everyone is as lucky. There are still areas of the world with limited access to doctors and clean water, resulting in higher rates of disease and lower life expectancy.

BIONIC BODIES

If medical science continues to progress at this rate, it could be possible to replace half of the human body in 50 years. Vital organs, including the heart, can already be transplanted. Joints, such as knees and hips, are often swapped for plastic replicas, which can do the job just as well. In the future, our bodies could become bionic, with bones of carbon-fiber titanium making us stronger. But be careful what you wish for. The reality of immortality may bore you to death . . .

KILLING TIME

If you think you have infinite time, you might not make the most of it, or you might do everything you want to do and then get bored. The human condition is prone to boredom, so just imagine keeping yourself entertained forever. Family and friends pass away. Everything you care about ends up either dead or mundane through repetition. What would you look forward to? In many ways, it is the knowledge that there will be an end to our lives that gives the beginning and middle its meaning and provides the motivation to keep going and do things. Perhaps it is better to make the most of your time on Earth, and when it's up, leave behind your personal legacy. In the words of American novelist Chuck Palahniuk (1962-), "We all die. The goal isn't to live forever; the goal is to create something that will."